Dante Merlino, MD, PhD

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Clinic and Academic Interests

- **Surgical**: Comprehensive management of head and neck malignancies—including mucosal and salivary gland tumors—with emphasis on microvascular reconstruction and transoral robotic surgery.
- **Multidisciplinary focus**: collaboration among surgical, medical, and radiation oncology teams, with particular interest in promoting and developing clinical trials.
- **Healthcare Informatics and Data Science:** Experienced in data integration and analysis using Epic (Clarity/Caboodle), SQL, Databricks, and Google Cloud Platform, AI-assisted extraction of tabular data from unstructured text (pathology reports, readmission notes, imaging studies, outside records). Skilled in developing secure, reproducible analytics pipelines and dashboards to evaluate quality metrics, accelerate retrospective research studies, and highlight clinical outcomes. Experienced in automation of administrative tasks (tumor board emails, resident coverage calendars) using Microsoft Power Automate.

Current Roles and Early Career Roadmap

Timeline	Clinical Focus	Research / Data Analytics
Year 1	Establish surgical practice; provide coverage for complex ablative and reconstructive cases	As Quality Director, lead department quality dashboards; as Surgeon Informaticist, build EHR tools and automate tumor board summaries
Years 2–3	Expand ablation/reconstruction & TORS volume; provide surgical and clinical mentorship to residents and fellows	Launch prospective registry of outcomes and patient-reported metrics; submit R21/Core grant; join AHNS focus groups
Years 3–5	Maintain tertiary referral role in ablation/reconstruction; establish role in complex salvage cases; continue mentorship of residents and fellows	Scale prospective trials and registry outputs; integrate institutional and multi-site data for comparative outcomes research

Mentorship and Professional Growth

I value apprenticeship-based learning and candid feedback. My near-term goals include refining complex decision-making in salvage and irradiated fields, working with departmental leadership to develop and expand my understanding of enterprise-wide relationships and responsibilities, and procuring funding for the department to promote and support analytics-led research.

My immediate goal is to deliver high-quality surgical care at UI Health and develop a departmental data warehouse that will serve as the foundation for prospective trials, grant funding, and long-term programmatic growth.